modern Indians paying their respects to an ancient imperial pillar in order to petition medieval spirits.

Feroze Shah ascended the throne in middle-age and ruled till he died after several years of illness at the age of eighty-one. As with Ashoka, his empire was already weakening while he was alive and, after his death, there was a quick succession of ineffective rulers. The Turko–Mongol marauder Taimur the Lame (also known as Tamerlane) saw his opportunity and swept into the country from Central Asia in 1398. He defeated the Sultan's army with ease and entered Delhi. Exclusively Muslim enclaves were spared, everything else was pillaged and the entire Hindu population was either massacred or taken away as slaves. [22] Taimur later wrote in his diary, 'I was desirous of sparing them but could not succeed as it is the will of God that this calamity should befall this city'. Somehow, I am not convinced.

Not surprisingly, after this episode, Delhi went into a period of decline. For the next one and a half centuries, the most important city in India would be Vijaynagar in the far south. We will return to it later. Meanwhile, the Tughlaqs were replaced by a succession of minor dynasties. Although the empire was much diminished, Delhi's patchwork of urban habitations continued to be a political and economic hub of some importance. Like all dynasties that have ruled this city before and after, the rulers of this period also built grand memorials to themselves. One can visit some of them at Lodhi Gardens in the heart of New Delhi, one of the most beautiful city parks in the world. The rich and powerful of modern India come here for their walks and to discuss the affairs of the world. It is also a good place to watch the extraordinary variety of birds that inhabit Delhi.

In 1526, a Turko–Mongol adventurer called Babur defeated the Sultan of Delhi in what is known as the First Battle of Panipat. We know a great deal about Babur because he has left us a fascinating account of his life in the form of a diary written in Turkish, the *Tuzuk-i-Baburi*. He was a shameless opportunist, but comes across as a loveable rogue. His enemies may not have seen him as loveable though—I suppose there are some advantages to writing your own history.